

WEEKEND SPECIAL

INTERVIEW

I Preach For Change Through My Music

What does the name Eckobig stand for?

It means uncommon grace and unusual favour. The name was given to me by God Himself.

Did God come down from heaven to give you the name?

(He laughs loudly, amused by the question). After I gave my life to Christ in 2007, God gave me the name through divine inspiration. It is just like the story of Jacob who became Israel in the Holy Bible, which signifies that old things have passed away and new beginning has come.

What genre of music do you play?

My music is based on contemporary issues like child abuse, terrorism, rape, kidnapping, and so on, that are commonplace in the world today. It sounds secular but my songs are inspired by biblical messages to make a positive change in listeners' minds.

What is the title of your first album?

My first single from my up-coming album is titled Change! Yes We Can. The video is already out and is being promoted on Youtube, facebook, and some other blogs portals. I have more than 1000 likes and 5000 followers within two months. It is a frontrunner for an upcoming seven-track album. It is a blend of R&B, rap and soul. DOC, Kelly, 2MS and Peace are some of the artistes that feature in the album.

What is your reason for choosing music as a medium to effect change?

Music is an effective avenue to express your motives for people to key in. Though, there is no marketer for the work now, I am not being limited or discouraged by that. I depend

The Nigerian music scene is daily churning out new talents spreading one form of message or the other for a better society. One of such new voices is Eckobig Chidiebere Anthony, who has just released a promotional single track into the music arena. In this interview with **Uzo Chikere** and **Blessed Mudiaga Adjekpagbon**, he beams on his passion for music and sundry issues.

more on social media and conventional media to make it reach the public.

physical distribution of the work will come later.

omaku. I finished my secondary education in 1997.

Who produced the album and what plans are in place to market it?

The album was produced, mixed, and mastered by E-Base in E-Base studios. Marketing in terms of

Where is your state of origin?

I am from Umuomaku in Orumba South Local Government Area of Anambra State. I attended Union Secondary School, Umu-

If you are asked to describe yourself, what would you say?

I am an entrepreneur; artiste and motivational speaker that love to motivate budding artistes. I believe in the philosophy that the sky is only a starting point in terms of more songs I am preparing to release. This single is not just a flash in the pan project.

Why did you prefer playing music instead of furthering your education?

It is not as if I am not interested in furthering my education. The poor background I came from was responsible for my non-furtherance for some time, but I am planning to enrol soon into the National Open University of Nigeria (NOUN). I went into business after my secondary education, and after three years, I left my master with the hope of travelling abroad for greener pastures. My efforts to travel out to Europe or America fell like a pack of cards when I was duped by fraudsters.

Can it be assumed that you like music more than education considering that you came out with a musical single at the expense of education?

There is a time frame for everything in life. Education is good, but there are certain things you need to do at the right time as the inspiration comes, otherwise you may never have the opportunity to actualize them again. That is the spirit of music. In my own philosophy, an educated person is someone who knows how to get what he/she wants, not necessarily the ability to read or write, but reasoning well.

What type of change are you using your music to propagate?

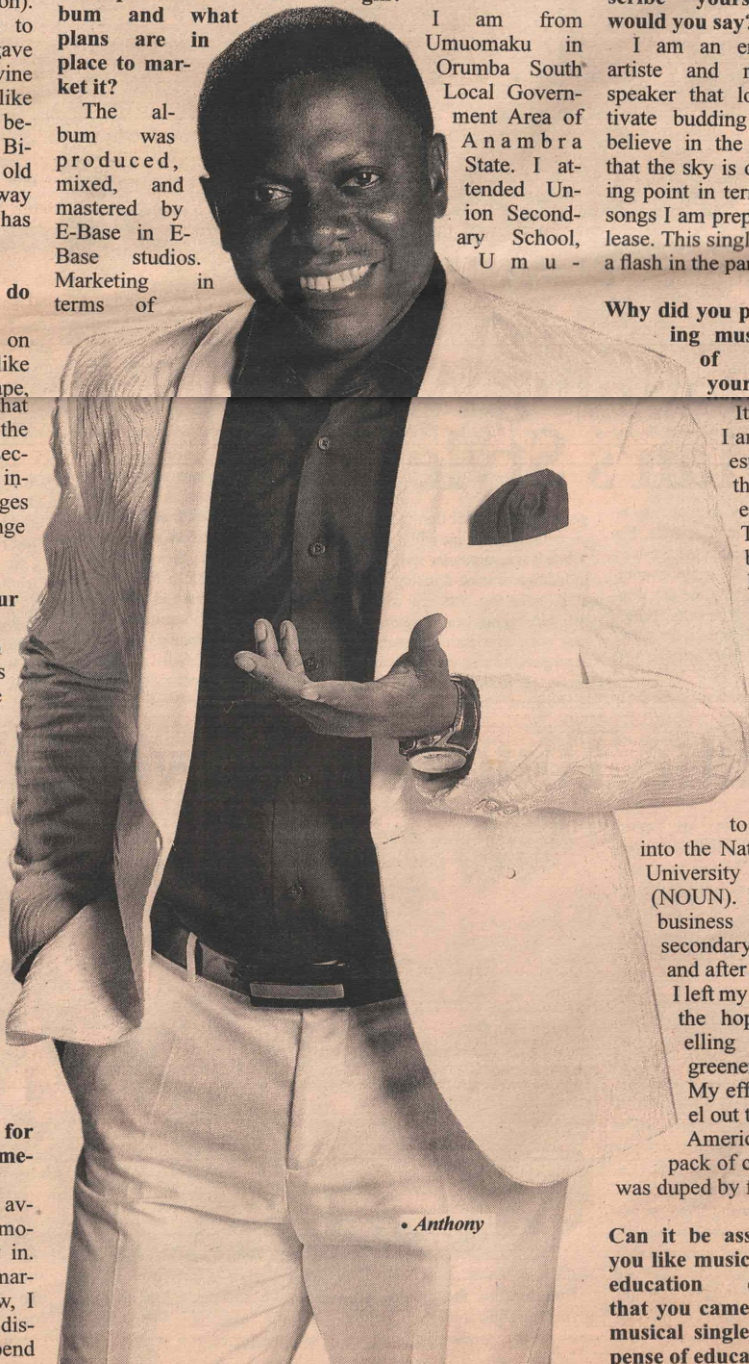
I want to see a changed world restored to peace, righteousness, goodness, and free from bribery, corruption, brutality, hostility, terrorism and racism. That is the idea behind the album's title.

Change you think looking the could be possible soon?

It may not happen immediately, but the change in American democracy which brought President Barack Obama to power today was envisioned by Martin Luther King Jr, many years before it came to reality. I also want a general change in the ways things are done in our country. I wonder why Nigeria cannot be well organized like some well administered foreign countries. Many times I travelled to Dubai and Qatar, I wondered why our country cannot be well planned and organized like them, even when we have the resources that surpass theirs. It is a question of changing our general attitude in the ways we manage our environment and resources.

Where do you expect the change to start from?

The change should begin from everybody, but most especially from our leaders. The youths no longer have focus for integrity and hard work because of the way many elders behave these days. Lack of focus and credible role models are part of the things affecting youths, which we need to change.



• Anthony

Entertainer

you date a married boss in real life?

First of all, I am against office romance and secondly, why contest for someone else's husband when there are so many free men out there?

How would you like your man to handle you?

I like a man who can treat me like a queen, understand and appreciate me.

What if he treats you like a queen but turns out deficient in the bedroom?

Well, when we get to that bridge we will know how to cross it.

Is it true that virtually all women like men that are vulgar, I mean, no-holds-barred-men?

I would say that it is different strokes for different folks.

What about you?

Every woman desires a romantic man and I am not an exception.

How challenging was *Friendly Scorpion*?

The script was challenging being my first Nollywood outing. More so, I had to put up with popular actors like Omotola Jalade-Ekeinde, Mike Ezuruonye, Solomon Akiyesi, Rukky Sanda and the likes, so I sincerely found it challenging. Although, I grew up writing scripts and acting from my primary school days, but camera-wise, *Friendly Scorpion* was my first.

Your mum was an actress, would it be right to describe yours as an entertainment family?

Yes, it would. I think that we took after our mother. She was into acting and the creative arts. She told us that she joined a drama group as a toddler. Today, my siblings and I are into entertainment; we sing and act. But my only brother is late now so, it's just my sister and I. My sister launched her album on June 21 and I am currently working on my debut single.

What genre would it be?

It's gospel. It's all about glorifying God for his goodness to me, especially for seeing me through this uneasy journey. God willing, the album will drop before the end of the year.

Why do you not wear tattoos or do you have them where the eyes cannot see them?

No, I don't wear tattoos. I think the Holy Bible condemns it and I would not do what goes contrary to biblical teachings, because I love and fear God.

What would you not do as an actress because of your faith?

It depends on the circumstance. If I am faced with a challenge and it is against my Christian faith, I would not do it.

What about going nude in a movie?

I can't. I wouldn't do that for any reason or any amount. But I'm not against those who do it because they are comfortable with it.

Even with a N5 million upfront pay?

I will not even if you give me all the money in the world.

You're supposed to be a professional, is going nude not part of make-belief?

It depends on how you view it. But like

I said, it is a personal thing. I cannot go nude in a movie.

What special qualities must your ideal man have?

I desire a God-fearing person because I'm very God-fearing too. I like a man that has focus, vision and a goal-getter. And of course, he has to be romantic and understanding.

Is it possible to find a man with those qualities in Nollywood?

Yes, it is possible.

Can you marry an actor or entertainer?

Yes I can.

Don't you think that challenges are usually higher when entertainers marry each other?

I think that one thing that keeps a relationship going, whether it is marriage or a dating, is understanding. Adequate understanding is all that matters.

What offence could make you deny your husband sex?

It depends because I've grown to be a very understanding person. Marriage is not just about relationship and sex; friendship matters a lot. Normally, men do things that shatter women's hearts. But personally, I have come to a point in my life where I have realised that 'hey, these are men for you; that's what they are and you have to deal with it that way'. So, I'll do everything to ensure we don't have unnecessary issues that will degenerate to such a level.

Would you break your husband's head if you catch him pants down on your matrimonial bed?

No, I would pretend that it is not a big deal and walk away.

You'd just walk away, speechless?

Yes, speechless. Maturity is not about making noise. If I start ranting, either the woman loses regard for me or my husband does. I would just make sure they see me before I walk away. So, it is up to my man to do the whole begging and apologies. I could even leave the house for a while or something of that sort. But such is not an easy experience because even if you have to cheat on me, it should not be on my matrimonial bed.

Do you think that all men cheat?

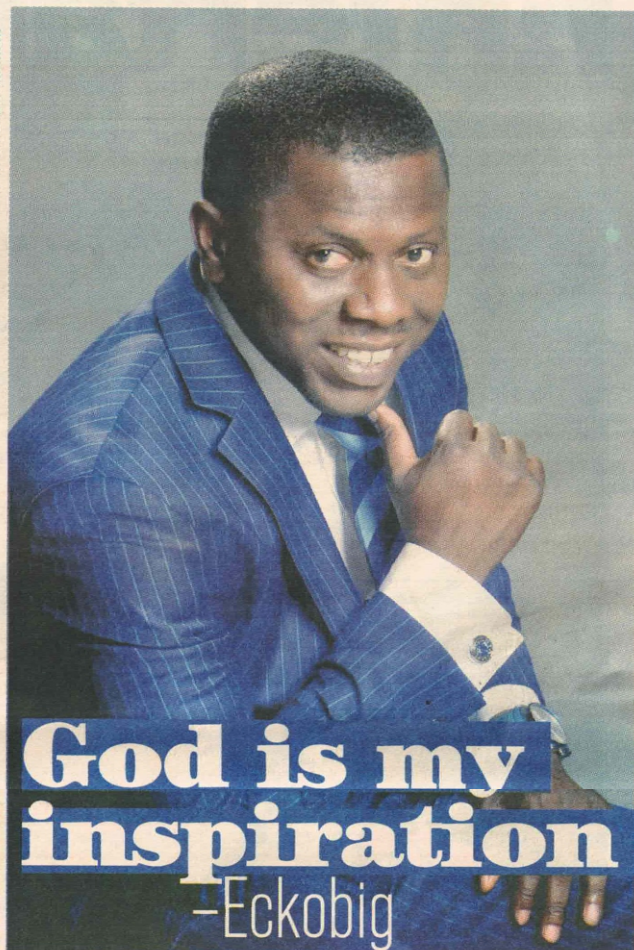
No, but I would say a majority do. There is this belief that 99.9 per cent of men cheat. So, it is just a minute fraction that doesn't. The truth is that there are still one or two men out there who don't.

What about women, don't they cheat too?

Well, I wouldn't say all women cheat because personally, I can't cheat on my man. I can only speak for myself. But seriously, I think that men cause most of the problems that women face today.

Can you dump your man over 'bedroom deficiency'; I mean poor performance in bed?

That is a complicated one I must confess. For my husband, marriage is for better for worse. So, that is a no-no. But for a boyfriend, if I try to explain to him and there is no improvement, I will leave because sincerely, no matter how you fake it, you will not be happy in such a relationship.



God is my inspiration

-Eckobig

By CHRISTIAN AGADIBE

Eckobig Chidiebere is an up-and-coming singer dreaming big. In this chat with Entertainer, Eckobig talks career and the journey so far.

Excerpts:

Tell us about your background?

My name is Eckobig Chidiebere Anthony. I am from Orumba South LGA of Anambra State. I am from a family of 10 children; eight boys and two girls. I am the third son and third born. I come from a very humble background. My parents were small business owners. I started hustling from a very tender age. My growing up was rough and tough although I enjoyed every bit of it. Growing up from a very poor background was not easy but to God is the glory, I'm here today. I used to be a chorister back then in my village church. I loved music, especially worship songs and R&B.

Let's talk about your singles? How is the acceptance?

The new song, *Change Yes We Can*, is gaining ground as change is the topic of discussion for almost all Nigerians today. People are calling from all over and commending me for a good job.

How do you get inspiration to write songs?

My inspiration comes from God alone. He uses things around me to inspire me. Things like people, environment, weather, nature, children, hardship, pains, suffering, blessings, prosperity and everything even death.

Can you describe your style of music?

My style of music is rare. I regard it as a poetic. I do a lot of inspirational talk although I would have preferred being a rapper but God did not give me the grace.

What are the challenges you are currently facing?

My challenge presently is getting a good record label either home or abroad that will understand my vision and get acquainted with my style of music so I can make great and positive impact globally.

Which top musicians have influenced your music career?

In Nigeria, Tuface Idibia has inspired me a lot. So too has Frank Edward and Lara George. Globally I love the music of Don Moen, R Kelly, Donnie MacClukkin and Kirk Franklin.

What record label are you working under the moment?

I used to be affiliated with Stingomania360 but never got signed on.

In the next five years, where do you think music will take you to?

In the next five years, music by God's grace will take me to global stardom and bring me to limelight.

Aside music, what else do you do?

Aside music I am an environmental activist, an international business man, an evangelist, actor, writer and a motivational speaker.

Dude Style

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'I like to look corporate and smart'

Anambra State-born singer, **Eckobig Chidiebere**, recently dropped a new single entitled, 'Change'. The singer, who combines business with showbiz, tells **VICTOR UDOH** that he likes to dress corporate and smart as dressing well is a serious business, among others. Excerpts:

Tell us about your background.

I hail from Orumba south LGA of Anambra State. I come from a very humble family of 10 children: eight boys and two girls. My parents were small business owners.

What are you working on?

I am currently working on so many projects. There is my brand ambassador advert to campaign for clean environment and good hygiene standards by the citizenry, among others.

About your single album, how accepted is it on air?

The new song, 'Change' is gaining grounds, as change is the topic of discussion to almost all Nigerians today. People are calling from everywhere to comment on the excellent job done on it.

What inspires your songs?

God is the source of all great and wonderful inspirations, so in that wise my inspirations come from Him alone, though He won't come down from heaven to give me inspiration. He uses people and things to inspire me. There is the environment, weather, nature, birds, children, suffering, blessings, prosperity, everything, even death, which inspire me.

Can you describe your style of music?

My style of music is rare and uncommon. As a poetic vocalist or singer, I do a lot of inspirational talking. Were I to choose however, I would have preferred to be a rapper.

but God did not give me that grace.

However, in all my past and present works, I have enjoyed working with people. I love collaboration. I love all genres of music as long as the lyrics are meaningful.

What are your current challenges?

My present challenge includes getting a good record label either home or abroad that will understand my vision about music, and help my style flourish in order to make great and positive impact with it globally.

What top musicians influenced your career?

In Nigeria, 2face Idibia inspired me a lot in his early days with the Plantation Boys until they separated. There is Frank Edward, Sinach, and Lara George. Globally I love the music of Don Moen, R Kelly in his early days, Donnie Macclurkin, and Kirk Franklin.

What are you doing to climb the ladder of success in music?

I would love to feature as many top artists that are within my reach, particularly, 2face Idibia.

What are you doing to climb the ladder of success in music?

I believe in creativity but depend mostly on the grace of God for my success. I hate imitation because it is the mother of limitation. I however love being myself even when so many people don't like what I do, but I always ensure I give my best possible. It is all about looking at what everybody else sees.

What are you record label with?
I used to be affiliated with St-nia360 record ingoma-

Among top artists, who do you plan to fea-

la-bel,

an indigenous record label based in Omaha, Nebraska in USA, but never got signed on.

Where do you see your music in the next five years?

In the next five years, music by God's grace, will take me to global stardom and bring me into the limelight.

How was your growing up?

It was rough and tough, though I enjoyed every bit of it. Growing up from a very humble background is not easy but to God be all the glory. I used to be a chorister in my village church, but I love sound and music, especially worship songs and R&B.

Aside from music, what other things do you do?

I am also an environmental activist, international businessman, evangelist, actor, writer and motivational speaker.

Have you ever been discouraged about music?

Yes, somehow my wife was very sceptical about my going into music because of the ugly stories that go with stardom. However, I assured her that God is with me and in control.

Who is your celebrity model and why?

My celebrity model in Nigeria is Nkem Owoh. I have never had a dull moment watching him on home movies, he is so real and very humorous. Another person is Mr. Bean, a UK actor. I love his humorous style of acting.

What content has your music?

My music, both past and present, talks and will continue to emphasise on change. That is holistic change, both for government and the governed. Any music that will not encourage people for positive change in all ramifications is not worth it.

What is your philosophy of life?

Be the best you can in everything you do. Don't look at other people to plan your life. Put all hope in God, he will sure make a way for you where there is no way; remain focused.

Can you define your dress style?

I like to look corporate and smart, because, looking good is a serious business.

What is that fashion item you love to wear?

I am comfortable on suite, because it brings out the best in my personality. It also makes me more responsible and presentable, especially when I am on stage.

